

THE RAM FACTOR
PM Modi arrives for the consecration ceremony at the Ram temple, in Ayodhya, Jan. 22

consistently drawn a blank in the Lok Sabha, the party was hoping to make a dent in the ruling DMK's strong alliance, which includes the Congress. But the BJP's key ally, the AIADMK, snapped ties with it after it refused to rein in its party president and rising star K. Annamalai. The latter, meanwhile, completed his 10,000-km En Mann En Makkal (My Land, My People) yatra, which culminated in a rally addressed by Modi recently. The BJP is also tying up with smaller parties such as former NDA member Pattali Makkal Katchi (PMK) headed by Anbumani Ramadoss. Meanwhile, it has fielded Annamalai, a former IPS officer, from Coimbatore, former Telangana governor Tamilisai Soundararajan from Chennai South and former Union minister Pon Radhakrishnan from Kanyakumari.

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On January 22 this year, Modi became the prime mover and conductor of the spectacular demonstration of Hindu revival and resurgence at the pran pratishtha ceremony of the new

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Ram mandir that had been built with astonishing speed at Ayodhya. Coming after the 2019 Supreme Court verdict that finally settled the decades-old bloody struggle over the site, the Ram temple is expected to generate tremendous emotional connect among the country's Hindu majority. Along with the grand makeover at Varanasi with the Kashi Vishwanath Corridor under Modi's watch, the epochal event was emblematic of the 'cultural renaissance' that the ruling BJP and its mentor, the Rashtriya Swayamsevak Sangh (RSS), hope to bring about if the party continues to rule the country. To keep the momentum of the Ram mandir's grand consecration going, the BJP has been organising 'Ayodhya darshans', as part of which it felicitates 5,000 pilgrims from 20-25 constituencies daily, asking them to take home prasad for an additional 5,000 families. On April 17, two days before the first phase of polling, PM Modi is likely to visit Ayodhya on the occasion of Ramnavami to offer prayers at the new temple. This is bound to effect an upswing in religious sentiments and benefit the BJP.

Mandir politics apart, the BJP has also gladdened the hearts of its core support base with the recent implementation of the Uniform Civil Code in Uttarakhand, the publishing of the rules to implement the CAA, not to mention the abrogation of Article 370 in Jammu and Kashmir at the start of its second term. By meeting these core objectives of the Sangh Parivar, Modi has attained iconic status among his Hindutva backers besides establishing himself in the public perception as a deliverer of promises. However, reputed psephologist Pradeep Gupta, founder of Axis My India, feels the Ram mandir will have the maximum electoral impact in Uttar Pradesh, which, at 80, has the largest number of Lok Sabha seats. In 2019, the BJP had won 62 of these seats, and its allies two more. The party sees the 16 seats it lost as crucial to its bid to breach the 400 target.

To ensure a clean sweep this time, the BJP has made a series of quick moves. It has co-opted a string of smaller parties to cater to various caste combinations. Thus, it has wooed back Jayant Chaudhary's Rashtriya Lok Dal (RLD), which has influence over the Jat farmers in UP, and Om Prakash Rajbhar's Suheldev Bharatiya Samaj Party (SBSP), apart from accommodating its older allies, the Nishad Party and Apna Dal (Sonelal)—thus mopping up the representatives of important backward class and Dalit groups in eastern UP. Explaining the BJP's alliance strategy not just in UP but also in other states, home minister Shah said at the India Today Conclave this year, "Alliance is not just about mathematics, it is also about chemistry and physics. 1 plus 1 may not become 2; in politics, it can become 11." Alluding to the Opposition, he added, "In the worst case, it can also become zero."

However, even as it cashes in on the Hindutva card, the BJP has been careful to defuse the demand for a national caste census with more lofty aspirations. Modi, in fact, has been saying he recognises only four jatis—the poor, youth, women and farmers—and often reiterates how his government has delivered on welfare schemes for different sections of society. Indeed, the BJP has cleverly crafted a whole *labharthi varg* (beneficiary class), which is now a sizeable vote bank that it hopes will deliver votes. To drive home its message, the BJP has sent out its grassroots 'shakti kendras', manned by the party's army